A Concise Rite of the Glorious Cakrasaṃvara Empowerment

Śrīcakrasaṃvarābhiṣekaprakriyopadeśa-nāma · Toh 1431 · Derge Tengyur

A Concise Rite of the Glorious Cakrasaṃvara Empowerment, whose Sanskrit title is given as Śrī Cakrasaṃvarābhiṣekaprakriyopadeśa, is a short verse manual on the ritual of conferring empowerment in the Cakrasaṃvara tantric system. After paying homage to Vajrasattva, the author sets out to explain the stages of the empowerment rite tied to the yoga of the three wheels, through which beings of the three realms may reach the state of the Vajra Holder. The text first takes up the maṇḍala that must precede empowerment. It describes the drawn maṇḍala, with its preparation of the site, its lines, and its colors, and then makes a deeper point: beings themselves are by nature an already accomplished, nondual maṇḍala, while constructed forms are adopted for the sake of disciples. The work is Toh 1431 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the Indian tantric treatises and ritual manuals associated with the Cakrasaṃvara cycle.

In the language of India: śrī cakrasaṃbarṣeka prakriya upadeśa nāma. In the language of Tibet: A Concise Rite of the Glorious Cakrasaṃvara Empowerment.

I pay homage to glorious Vajrasattva.

The yoga itself of the three wheels in sequence,
Through which beings dwelling in the three realms
Attain the state of the Vajra Holder:
The stages of its empowerment rite I shall explain.

Vajradhara taught
That empowerment is preceded by a maṇḍala.
Yet what the nature of that maṇḍala is
Is explained as follows.

The drawn maṇḍala is taught through the stages
Of preparing the site, the lines, and laying out the colors.
But these very beings, by their nature,
Are an accomplished maṇḍala, free of duality.

Whatever has a fabricated nature
Is accepted for the sake of disciples.
It is not what the wise need to accomplish,

For seeing the true meaning, they are liberated.

The maṇḍala of the three wheels is accomplished;
The deities of the maṇḍala are accomplished.
Its stages of empowerment and the rest
Accomplish whatever has not yet been accomplished.

They are intended to make vessels
Of those who do not know its nature.
The stages of empowerment and the rest, conventionally,
Are what bring it about directly.

Divided as the master empowerment and the others,
Empowerment is taught to be fourfold.
Divided as the water empowerment and the others,
These four become fourteen.

First of all, the vajra master himself
Is by nature the three wheels.
Then he should imagine the disciple to be like himself,
And then he should accomplish everything.

"Son, this is nectar for you.
If not guarded, it burns, and so it is poison;
If guarded, it becomes accomplishment.
It is made of the water of the five nectars."

oṃ pañca amṛta udaka ṭha hūṃ

He should give it to him, contained in a skull cup:

"You must not disparage it,
Nor go against the commitments,
For you would go to hell and the like."

Then the descent should be performed.
Its procedure is this:
A loincloth stained with menstrual blood,
Thoroughly soaked in excrement, urine and the like,
And guggulu kneaded with cat dung,
Are mixed together and prepared.
Fire from a preta is taken up
And placed in a lotus vessel.

All those things are put into it.
Standing with the left leg extended,
The lord of the three wheels, the Wrathful One, causes the descent.
Before that lord of the three wheels,
The one who holds the vajra burns it, and then,
As it fumes, the descent comes without doubt.

tiṣṭha mahākrodha āveśaya hūṃ śrī herukāyi bidma bidmahe bidyārājaya dhimahe svāhā

With this mantra one should rouse the hero.

Then the maṇḍala should be shown:

"The self that is pure by nature,
The stainless nature of the body,
The abode of the heroes, the heroines, and the Lord:
Son, behold the maṇḍala!"

Then the sacred sites, the secondary sites, and the rest,
Abiding in the maṇḍala of oneself, the body maṇḍala,
Are by nature the thirty-seven
Factors of awakening.
The thirty-seven channels
Are the wheel of deities of the maṇḍala.
The major and minor limbs
Of glorious Heruka should be shown.

Then, bowing with his whole being,
The disciple should supplicate the guru, the protector:

"You whose nature is the truth of the Dharma, inconceivable,
Please confer empowerment upon me!"

As soon as the disciple has made this request,
The vase of victory and the others should be taken up.
The water held in the lotus vessel
Should be visualized by the vajra master
As Akṣobhya, arisen from a vajra
That arises from the syllable hūṃ.
Diligently invoking with the rays of the seed syllable
The nature of the wisdom being,

He should make that very wisdom enter.
Then he should take up the supreme water.
That very water, in the form of Akṣobhya,
Is the essence of the aggregate of consciousness.
This empowerment of the hero, the greatly loving Teacher,
Is given at the crown of the head.

oṃ cakra vīra tvaṃ abhiṣiñcayami

That is the water empowerment.

The crown as well, whether painted or otherwise:
In this way, from aṃ, the seed of the Jewel Holder,
Comes what is called the vajra-sun.
As explained, one generates it and duly worships it.
That is done as before.
It takes the form of the crown,
And this is of the nature of feeling.
Having imagined and generated it, the vajra holder
Places Vajraḍāka at the crown of the head.

With the mantra oṃ sarvabuddha ḍākinīye vajra varṇṇanīye huṃ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā, and likewise one recites other mantras as well. That is the crown.

From jriṃ, arisen from a lotus-vajra,
The tathāgata of perception,
Amitābha, is generated as a vajra.
It should be given by having the disciple hold it properly,
In the right hand and at the heart.

adhipati tvaṃ abhiṣiñca ṭha tvaṃ vīra śrī heruka dhibi eda rud sarvabuddha tvāṃ gṛhṇa vajra subidhaye

That is the vajra.

From the syllable khaṃ a sword arises,
Having the form of Amoghasiddhi.
The bell, the essence of formations,
Should be given into the left hand:

"This is declared to be followed
By all the bell sounds of all the yoginīs.
You yourself must always hold it;

The Victors regard it as supreme awakening.

In the hero's hands, vajra and bell
Are held: lord of the three wheels,
Beautiful by nature, joyful,
Be consecrated as the Great Seal!"

That is the lordship.

He places his hand on the crown of the disciple's head.
From bhrūṃ comes the form of Vairocana.
The vajra holder, essence of the aggregate of form,
Should confer the name empowerment.

oṃ śrī cakra adhipati śrī heruka vīra tvaṃ abhiṣiñcayami

"You are called Vajra So-and-so." That is the name.

In the mindstream that has received the five empowerments,
These five buddhas are pure,
And through freedom from ignorance
The five wisdoms are attained.

With the mantra of twenty-two syllables,
The mantra empowerment is then given:

"This is what glorious Heruka of all the buddhas
Holds in his hand.
You too must always hold it,
Steadfast in the discipline of glorious Heruka."

oṃ sarvatathāgata siddhi vajra samaya tiṣṭha eṣa tvaṃ dharāyami oṃ ha ha ha hī

That is the vajra discipline.

The khaṭvāṅga, the ḍamaru, and the begging bowl
Are given by the hero and received.
These insignia of glorious Heruka
Are perfect outwardly and inwardly.
With the left hand holding the vajra
And grasping the corner of the robe,
And with the right hand granting fearlessness,
He should give the disciple consolation:

"Thus I make this prophecy:
You, embodiment of the three wheels,
Yourself the nature of all the buddhas,
Are the very Tathāgata
Called Glorious Heruka."

śrī heruka ḍākinī namaḥ sarvatathāgata siddhiḥ samaya tvaṃ bhur bhuva svaḥ

"You have the great kingdom of the three realms,
Are the source of glorious qualities,
Are victorious over the māras and all others,
And have entered the supreme city."

That is the prophecy.

Then one should make supplication once more:

"Great empowerment of non-returning,
Great hero, bestow it upon me.
That which makes beings free of signs,
Please perform it here and now."

Then the lord of the three wheels,
The Teacher, by the seed syllable
At the heart of his own wisdom being,
Gradually summons, with perfect urging,
The heroes and the heroines,
With excellent offerings and service.
Likewise the tathāgatas who abide
In the vase filled with the water of wisdom:
The hero should visualize them
Conferring the empowerment of Vajradhara.

To the great vajra of empowerment,
To which the three realms pay homage,
The heroes of the three secrets of all the buddhas
Abide in yoga.
One should make offerings as one wishes,
And one should bestow what comes from that abode.

The mantra is also recited. Then, making Akṣobhya the crown ornament, one should cause the heroes and goddesses to abide upon it, reciting: oṃ

supratiṣṭha vajre svāhā. Then one makes offerings all around with the various kinds of offerings, such as flowers. Through the great heroes and the yoginīs, things will then turn out as one wishes. Then one should receive the command of the Vajra Holder:

"For the yogin who knows reality
There is nothing at all he may not do.
Having come to know reality,
The hero then enjoys the five sense pleasures.
I myself am the reality of all heroes;
I myself am the reality of all goddesses.
Therefore I shall do everything;
I myself shall worship Heruka.
Having the nature of dependent arising,
Beings are of the nature of illusion.
Having known the three realms in this way,
Accomplish the unequaled benefit of beings!"

The disciple who has done what was to be done
Then offers a fee to the lord,
And to the gathering of holy persons
Offers praise and homage with his whole being.

That is the non-returning empowerment.

"Having done what is to be done before the wheel,
To the great guru, eye of the wheel,
To that very hero, I bow down."
Then one should request the teaching of the secret:

"Protector of the unprotected, refuge of the refugeless,
Glorious one, supreme bliss of the wheel,
Great compassion without any cause,
Be the protector of me who has no protector!
Just as you are, O great being,
O lord, make me likewise.
In the vast mass of the mire of saṃsāra,
Be a refuge for me who am sinking!"

Here the sequence of mudrās is this: among the mudrās that are pure in their nature as the families of the five seed syllables, the Dharma mudrā, the great mudrā and the samaya mudrās are all held to be women. Thus the glorious

vajra master, by the power of his great compassion, in the deep of night, in a secluded chamber, having obtained a mudrā, any highly secret goddess endowed with the samaya, then from their absorption whatever arises is of an unborn nature:

"All the heroes perfectly assembled,
All the goddesses joined in union:
The conventional mind of awakening,
That which is secret, with it I empower you.
This is the great and wondrous samaya
Of the heroes and the goddesses;
Endowed with the five elements, it brings realization of taste.
Whatever that bliss may be, it is to be savored."
Abiding in the lotus, he practices perfectly,
And, addressing the Teacher, he says:
"Oh, great bliss!"
The disciple too destroys conceptual thought.
"Just as Vajradhara and the others
In the past empowered their sons,
So too with the excellent mind of awakening
I empower you, my son."

That is the secret empowerment.

After that comes a consort blessed by oneself, or, according to another's text, "and others besides"; that is, she is given by the Teacher, and through her one accomplishes the supreme.

"This goddess is the great mudrā,
The bestower of infinite bliss.
In every way, take the mudrā!
Son, make the unsurpassed offering!"

That is the wisdom empowerment.

Then that goddess makes a request to the unsurpassed hero:

"Hero, to partake of the mind of awakening,
Are you eager, or what?
Arising from the five families,
Are you devoted to worshipping the consort?
Excrement, urine, flesh and blood

And the rest, do you now have faith to eat them?
Speaking in accord, of excellent samaya,
Tell me, son, how pleased you are."

"These samayas and the rest thus taught,
O goddess, why would I not be eager?
Why would I not always revere women?
Why would I not worship the lotus?"

Then that goddess, delighted,
With hair unbound and garments shed,
Having opened wide the lotus,
Displays it: bhañca padma ho.
The channel abiding at the center of the lotus,
From which bliss flows down, is to be shown.
Stimulating each in turn with the fingers,
And dwelling on the tasting with the tongue,
She who speaks of the accomplishment of reality
Brings about the innate bliss.
The experience, the supreme joy,
Arises, and one savors its bliss.

Then that Blessed Lady, displaying joy, speaker of the profound mantra,
Placing her left hand upon the crown of his head,
Should give the prophecy for what is to follow:

"From this day forth, son, you,
Until the heart of awakening,
For all beings, who are like a dream,
Work for their benefit with your whole being."

That is the wisdom-gnosis empowerment.

Those three stages are to be known here
Through the instruction of the guru.
This is beautiful in itself,
Having abandoned outer objects.
If one abandons this family,
By other means there is no buddhahood.
Practice the discipline of the consort, son!
Of all disciplines, the highest of the high

Is the discipline of the consort.

The water empowerment and the rest, up to non-returning,
Are explained as the master empowerment.
Whatever of these is taught outwardly
All abides within.
The conduct of the heroes, divided into its stages,
Is to be known through the instruction alone.

The four empowerments that have been taught,
When they become the empowerment of the discipline,
Are for the sake of attaining the inconceivable Dharma.
Then this, which is called "reality,"
Is rightly explained as outer and inner.
The nature of the outer and inner is explained:
It is the essence of all phenomena,
And is explained as "inconceivable."
Without appearance, fully complete, without abode,
That is the fifth, the stage of completion:
Innate, inexhaustible,
Inconceivable, infinite, and so on.
It is the very self of beings, stable and moving;
Through selflessness it abides as the self.
The hero realizes great bliss.
This is the instruction on suchness.

The Concise Stages for Conferring the Empowerment of Glorious Cakrasaṃvara, composed by the master Vajraghaṇṭāpāda, is complete.

This is the explanation of the unerring lineage of Śrī Phanaphiguba. It was translated by the Indian preceptor, the paṇḍita Kṛṣṇa, and the Tibetan translator, the monk Chökyi Sherab.

Translator's Notes

• "Fire from a preta" renders the Tibetan literally. It most likely refers to fire taken from a cremation pyre or charnel ground.

"The Jewel Holder" translates a name that here stands for the buddha of the feeling aggregate, normally Ratnasambhava. Because the exact Sanskrit form intended is uncertain, the meaning has been given in English.

The line about the five empowerments could also be read as "from the tantra." It has been taken here as referring to the disciple's mindstream, in which the five buddhas are pure.
• "Flesh" renders □□□□□ (literally "strength," Skt. bala), which in the coded language of the Hevajra and Saṃvara tantras stands for flesh among the sacramental substances. "What comes from that abode" is a literal rendering of a terse line whose exact referent is unclear. "I myself shall worship Heruka" could also be read as "I myself, as Heruka, am to be worshipped." The lineage name □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ in the colophon could not be identified with confidence and is given as it is spelled.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.